peaceful settlement very greatly and led inevitably, step by step, to conflict.

The choice had to be made very soon now by the peasants and by the Congress; we could not postpone our decision till Gandhiji's return. What were we to do? What advice to give? Could we reasonably ask the peasants to pay up the sum demanded within the short period allowed when we knew that many of them could not possibly do so? And then what of the arrears due from them? Would they not run the risk of dispossession even if they paid a large part of the sum demanded, or even the full current demand, which might be credited to arrears?

The Allahabad District Congress Committee, with its strong peasant contingent, showed nght. It decided that it could not possibly advise the peasants to pay. It was told, however, that it could not take any aggressive step without the formal permission of the Provincial Executive as well as of the All-India Working Committee. The matter was, therefore, referred to the Working Committee, and both Tasadduq Sherwani and Purushottam Das Tandon were present to place the case for the province and the district. The question before us related to Allahabad district only and it was a purely economic issue, but we realised that, in the state of political tension then existing, it might have far-reaching consequences. Should the Allahabad District Committee be permitted to advise the peasants in the district to withhold payment of rent or revenue for the time being and pending further negotiation and better terms? This was the narrow issue and we wanted to confine ourselves to it, but could we do so? The Working Committee wanted to strain every nerve to prevent a break with Government before Gandhiji's return, and, in particular, it wanted to avoid a break on an economic issue which might develop into a class issue. The Committee, though politically advanced, was not so socially, and it disliked the raising of the tenant *versus* zamindar question.

Being socialistically inclined, I was not considered a very safe person to advise on economic and social matters. I myself felt that the Working Committee should realise that the U.P. situation was such that even our more moderate and right wing members were being forced by events to take action, in spite of all their disinclination for it. I welcomed, therefore, the presence of Sherwani and others from our province at our Committee meeting, for Sherwani (our Provincial President) was by no means a fire-brand. Constitutionally he was a right winger in the Congress, both politically and socially, and, at the begin-